First Nations Vocabulary – using culturally appropriate language and terminology

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We have recently received advice that the Minister for Indigenous Australians, the Hon Linda Burney MP, has a preference to use the term 'First Nations peoples' when referring to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples. In line with the 2022 Reconciliation Week theme of Be Brave and Make a Change, here are some tips to start making the change.

Be consistent. The preference is to use 'First Nations peoples', 'Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people(s)', or 'Indigenous Australians'. Choose one and stay consistent, including in data tables and graphs.

Use capital letters, it's a noun – First Nations, Aboriginal Australian, Indigenous Australian, Torres Strait Islander. **When referencing to Elders, capitalise the 'E' as it is a title.** Capital letters also apply to Native Title, Traditional Owners, Custodians and Culture.

Avoid acronyms or shortening words. Always use the full words. Acronyms or shortened versions are considered offensive. The only time you can use an acronym is if it's a part of a recognised organisation name such as AIATSIS.

Use traditional place names where possible. If you are not sure of the traditional place name (for example 'Palawa' or 'Gadigal'), visit the AIATSIS Map of Indigenous Australia - external site.

Terminology can change over time and, where possible, it is best practice to find out what the preferred term is from the respective Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander group or individual you are referring to. For further guidance, please see the Australian Government Style Manual - external site.
https://healthinfonet.ecu.edu.au/healthinfonet/getContent.php?linkid=675466&title=The+Australian+Indigenous+HealthInfoNet+guidelines+for+Aboriginal+and+Torres+Strait+Islander+terminology&contentid=44676_1

Capitalising E in Elder

https://www.apsc.gov.au/working-aps/diversity-and-inclusion/diversity-inclusion-news/first-nations-vocabulary-using-culturally-appropriate-language-and-terminology

Elder

The traditional meaning of an Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Elder is someone who has gained recognition within their community as a custodian of knowledge and lore, and who has permission to disclose cultural knowledge and beliefs. Recognised Elders are highly respected people within Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities.

In some instances, Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people above a certain age will be referred to as 'Elders'. However, it is important to understand that in traditional Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures, age alone does not necessarily mean that one is a recognised Elder.

The use of Elder (uppercase) is generally acceptable, but it is important to be aware of the differences in meaning outlined above.

When negotiating with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities, ensure that recognised Elders are involved. This may occur directly, or through other Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people negotiating on the Elders' behalf. Although negotiation with recognised Elders is important, it should not replace negotiation with local Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander organisations, such as the local Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Community Controlled Health Organisation.